CONSULT FOR AFRICA

C2: Managing Through Others

The CFA MBA, Term 1

Workbook for Ezinne Orji and Abigail Oladejo

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How to use this workbook

Week	Dates	Section
1	9 to 13 Nov	The brief: writing work someone else can finish
2	16 to 20 Nov	Who, how much, and breaking work down
3	23 to 27 Nov	Check-ins, review and feedback
4	30 Nov to 4 Dec	Running a small team's week

- Each week: read the section, write the real briefs the exercise asks for on the platform, and answer the test on your task.
- Reviewer: Dr Adediwura Okeleye reads the briefs you wrote that week and marks them against the rubric in 1.6.
- Ezinne's track: the briefs are for Favour, Ruth and Abigail.
- Abigail's track: the briefs are to Mezo facilities and doctors, and requests to colleagues. The method is the same.

Week 1: The brief

1.1 Why delegation fails

Most delegated work goes wrong before it starts. The person was told what to do but not why, or not what finished looks like, so they guess. Then the work comes back wrong, the manager redoes it, and concludes it was faster to do it themselves. That conclusion is the trap. The fix is the brief, not the person.

- The test of a brief: could the person finish the work without asking you a single question?
- The cost: ten minutes writing a brief saves an hour of rework and a day of waiting.

1.2 The six parts, as the platform asks for them

Field on the task form	What to write	Weak	Strong
Task	A verb and an object	"Haven"	"Draft the Haven founders' update for Friday 13 Nov"
Assign to	One named person		
Brief: why this matters and what it feeds into	Who it is for, what they will do with it, what matters most	"Please do the update"	"The founders read this every Friday to decide what to push at the board. They care about cash, staffing and the NICU. If short of time, get those three right."
Definition of done	What finished looks like, checkable by someone else	"A good update"	"Five to eight bullets in the founders' update screen, each with a number or a date, nothing older than this week, saved as a draft for my review by 3pm Thursday."
Worked example	A finished one that is already right		"Last week's update, linked. Copy its shape."
Due, Check in, Estimate	When it is finished; when you look at progress; how long it should take	Due only	Due Thu 3pm, check in Wed 12pm, estimate 90 minutes

1.3 Five rules for the brief

- Outcome, not activity: say what must exist at the end, not what to do all day.
- Context before instruction: the person who knows why can make the small judgements you did not foresee.
- One owner: one name per task. Two names means nobody.
- Checkable done: if two people could disagree about whether it is done, the definition is not finished.
- Estimate honestly: if you think it takes two hours, say two hours. It tells them how deep to go.

1.4 Levels of delegation

Level	You say	Use when
1. Do exactly this	"Send this email to these five clinics."	New person, high-risk task
2. Look into it and recommend	"Find three venues and recommend one."	They know the area but not your preferences
3. Decide and tell me	"Book the venue within this budget and tell me which."	Trusted, reversible decisions
4. Own it	"The venue is yours."	Proven, and you are content with their call

- Say the level out loud in the brief. Most confusion comes from the person thinking they are at level 3 when you meant level 2.
- Move people up a level when they have done the work well at the level below. That is how they grow.

1.5 A brief rewritten

Weak:

> Ruth, please look into Medbury and send me something.

Strong:

> Task: Summarise what Medbury is waiting on from us, for Monday's partner pack.
>
> Brief: Debo reads the partner pack on Monday to decide what to chase. Medbury has three open strands and the record is out of date, so Debo cannot see what is stuck. Recommend (level 2), do not chase anyone yet.
>
> Definition of done: a table attached here, one row per open item: what it is, who owes it (us or them, by name), since when, and your suggested next step. Anything you could not confirm is marked "not confirmed". Done by Friday 5pm.
>
> Worked example: the Haven table in last week's pack.
>
> Check in: Thursday 12pm. Estimate: 2 hours.

1.6 The rubric your reviewer uses

Mark	The brief
5	Could be finished without a single question. Purpose, checkable done, example, level and timings all present.
4	One small gap the person could sensibly fill.

Mark	The brief
3	Done is clear but the why is thin, or the reverse.
2	The person would have to ask before starting.
1	A title and a deadline.

1.7 Exercise 1

- Ezinne: write and assign three real tasks this week: one each to Favour, Ruth and Abigail, from work that is genuinely on your plate. Take the Haven founders' update, the Monday pack, or something Debo has given you.
- Abigail: write three real requests: one to a Mezo facility (for example, confirming a doctor's clinic days and fee), one to a doctor's office, and one to a colleague at the firm. Send them where they belong and paste the text on your task.
- Both: paste the three briefs on your task, and say which level each is at.

1.8 Test 1

1. What is the test of a good brief?
2. Name the six parts of a brief as the task form asks for them.
3. Why does the brief carry the purpose, not just the instruction?
4. Rewrite this definition of done so it is checkable: "Make the minutes nice."
5. What is wrong with assigning one task to two people?
6. Name the four levels of delegation.
7. You want Favour to find three possible venues for a client dinner and tell you which is best. Which level?
8. Why should the estimate be honest even if it seems long?
9. What is a worked example, and when can you leave it out?
10. What is the difference between the due date and the check-in?

Week 2: Who, how much, and breaking work down

2.1 Choosing who

Question	Why it matters
Who has the skill, or should be building it?	Some work goes to the person who can do it best; some to the person who needs to learn it
Who has the room?	Look at their desk on the platform before you assign. Three overdue tasks means a fourth will be late too.
Whose engagement is it?	Favour is on Haven, Osteon and Arabella. Ruth is on Medbury, Medlyfe Introduces and House of Refuge. Keep work inside a person's engagements unless there is a reason.
Is it a growth task?	Give each person one task a fortnight that stretches them, with a stronger brief and an earlier check-in

2.2 What to keep

- Keep: anything only you can do because of your access or your relationship with Debo; decisions about priorities; the first conversation with a senior client.
- Delegate: anything with a clear done, anything repeated, anything someone else would learn from.
- The rule: if you are doing work an analyst could do while their desk is empty, you are underusing both of you.

2.3 Breaking work down

Debo's work often reaches you as one big item: "get the Arabella audit report out". The platform lets you break a task on your desk into sub-tasks, each with its own assignee. Debo sees the roll-up on the original task without the detail.

How:

1. Open the task on your desk.
2. Write the steps it really takes, in order.
3. For each step: who, by when, and what it depends on.
4. Add each step as a sub-task on the task page, with its own brief and definition of done.
5. Keep the parts that need you, and the final check, for yourself.

Example: "Get the Arabella interim report to Dr Chito by Friday" becomes:

- Favour: collect the outstanding data items from the engagement record, list what is missing. Due Tuesday.
- You: chase the missing items with the client. Due Wednesday.
- Favour: update the tables. Due Thursday 12pm.
- You: final read and send to Debo for approval. Due Thursday 5pm.

2.4 Reverse delegation

When someone brings you a problem and leaves it with you, the work has come back up. Instead of "leave it with me", ask: "What do you think we should do?" Then let them do it. Your job is to unblock, not to absorb.

2.5 Exercise 2

- Ezinne: take one large item on your desk and break it into at least three sub-tasks on the platform. Assign two more real tasks this week, one of them a stretch task.
- Abigail: take one Mezo patient request from start to finish and write down every handoff in it: who did what, who was waiting. Mark each handoff where a better brief would have saved time.
- Both: paste on your task what you did and why you chose each person.

2.6 Test 2

1. Name four questions to ask when choosing who to give a task to.
2. Why look at someone's desk before assigning to them?
3. Name two kinds of work you should keep.
4. What is a stretch task, and how do you brief it differently?
5. What does Debo see when you break one of Debo's tasks into sub-tasks?
6. What is reverse delegation, and what do you say instead of "leave it with me"?
7. A task has five steps. Which ones do you keep for yourself?

8. Ruth has three overdue tasks. You have an urgent new one. What do you do?
9. Why keep work inside a person's engagements?
10. Debo gives you a large task due Friday. What are your first three steps?

Week 3: Check-ins, review and feedback

3.1 The check-in

- Purpose: catch a wrong direction while it is cheap to fix.
- Ask to see the work, not to hear about it. "Show me what you have" beats "How is it going?"
- Three questions: what is done, what is next, what is in your way.
- If it is off course, say so now, plainly, and agree the fix.

3.2 Review

When a task is submitted, it comes to you because you assigned it. Review against the definition of done you wrote.

Outcome	When	What you write
Approve	It meets the definition of done	One line on what was good. Be specific.
Request changes	It does not meet it	Exactly what is missing or wrong, and what good looks like.

- Review within one working day. Work waiting for review is your delay, not theirs.
- Do not fix it yourself and approve. They learn nothing, and you have done the work twice.
- If the work is wrong because the brief was unclear, say so: "My brief did not say X. Please add it." That is honest and keeps trust.

3.3 Feedback

Use situation, behaviour, impact:

- Situation: when and where.
- Behaviour: what they did, observable, not a judgement of character.
- Impact: what it caused.

Weak	Strong
"You are careless."	"In Tuesday's minutes (situation), two names were misspelled and one action had no owner (behaviour). Debo had to correct them before sending to the client (impact)."
"Great job."	"Your Medbury table (situation) marked every unconfirmed item (behaviour), so Debo chased the right two things on Monday (impact)."

- Praise in specifics, so it is repeated.
- Correct in private, soon, and once. Then let it go.
- Ask before telling: "How do you think it went?" Most people already know.

3.4 When someone is blocked

- They mark the task blocked with a reason, and it comes to you.

- Respond the same day. Either remove the block, change the task, or change the deadline. Never leave it.

3.5 Exercise 3

- Ezinne: review every task waiting on you this week within one working day. For two of them, paste the review note you wrote. Hold one check-in with each analyst using the three questions and note what came out.
- Abigail: write the feedback you would give, in situation, behaviour, impact form, on two real Mezo interactions: one that went well, one that did not. No names of patients.
- Both: write one piece of feedback for each other on how you work together, and share it.

3.6 Test 3

1. What is the purpose of a check-in?
2. What three questions do you ask at a check-in?
3. Why review within one working day?
4. Why should you not fix someone's work yourself and approve it?
5. What do you write when the work is wrong because your brief was unclear?
6. What do situation, behaviour and impact mean?
7. Rewrite as SBI: "Your report was bad."
8. Why should praise be specific?
9. What must you do the same day a task is marked blocked?
10. When do you approve, and when do you request changes?

Week 4: Running a small team's week

4.1 The weekly routine

When	What
Monday morning	Read every desk. What is due this week, what is overdue, what is blocked. Set the three things that must happen.
Monday	Assign the week's new work with full briefs.
Wednesday	Check-ins on anything due Friday.
Daily	Clear blocks and reviews.
Friday	Review what came in. Note who did well and what slipped, for the monthly evaluation.

4.2 Priorities and conflicts

- Two people give an analyst work that clashes: they tell you. You decide, or take it to Debo if one of the two is a partner. Do not let them resolve it by working late.
- You are overloaded: tell Debo early, with a proposal. "I can do A and B this week. C slips to Tuesday unless you want it before B."

4.3 Asking people senior to you

You will often need things from people who do not report to you: a partner, a doctor client, a reviewer.

- Make it easy: a short message, the exact ask, the date, and why it matters.
- Record it: put it on the Commitments register with a name and a date, so it is followed up rather than forgotten.
- Follow up once, politely, on the date. Then escalate to Debo with the history.

4.4 Exercise 4

- Ezinne: run the full weekly routine for your team this week. On Monday, paste your three priorities. On Friday, paste a five-line note: what was delivered, what slipped and why, what you would brief differently.
- Abigail: run the same routine on your Mezo queue: every open request, its next step and its owner.
- Both: put one real ask to a senior person on the Commitments register.

4.5 Test 4

1. What do you look at on Monday morning?
2. Two people give Favour clashing work. What happens?
3. You cannot finish three things this week. What do you tell Debo, and how?
4. How do you ask a busy partner for something?
5. Why record a request on the Commitments register?
6. What do you note on Friday, and what is it for?

The practical: Friday 4 December

- Ezinne: Dr Okeleye picks five tasks you assigned during the course and marks them against the rubric. Then a 20-minute conversation: brief a task out loud for a scenario you are given.
- Abigail: the same, on five of your Mezo requests and briefs.
- Pass: an average of 4 on the rubric.